But I could see and that outweighed the effects of whatever ridicule I had to endure.

In school, I was always among the first in line when it came to participating in sports and other activities, and when someone in town decided that Dixon ought to have a boys' band, I wanted to be a part of it. I didn't play a musical instrument, but I wound up out in front of the band as drum major and felt very special about it.

My most memorable experience with the Dixon boys' band was a strange one.

We were invited to a nearby small town to play in the Decoration Day parade and were assigned to lead the parade just behind the parade marshal and his horse. Down the middle of the street we marched in our fancy white duck pants, bright tunics, and high, beaked hats. At one point, the marshal turned his horse around and rode back down the line of marchers to assure that everybody was in line; well, I kept marching down the street, pumping my baton up and down, in the direction I thought we were supposed to go. But after a few minutes I noticed the music behind me was growing fainter and fainter.

I turned around and discovered I was all alone: The band was gone.

The marshal had ridden back, gotten in front of the band, and had then led the parade down a cross street, but I didn't know it; the band just followed him and turned the corner; I'd kept going straight down the street. When I saw what had happened I started running, crossed several vacant lots and backyards, got in front of the band, and fell into step again.

It wasn't the last time, incidentally, that people have said I sometimes march to a different drummer.

As teenagers, Neil and I began calling our parents by their first names. It started one day when Neil, after enlisting my backing, told the folks that since we were such a close